While appreciating where we have reached today, it must also be acknowledged that this was not always the state of our ties. An honest account would start from the partition of the Subcontinent that diminished India's influence so much. An artificial twinning of India with Pakistan was deliberately created, one that was broken only in 1971. There was also for many years an interest in politically exploiting fissures within Indian society. The latitude extended even today to separatist activities citing democratic freedoms is troubling.

Western association in our neighbourhood till a few years ago was often with political forces that sought greater distance from India. If India's democratic values are currently extolled, this too was not always the case. On the contrary, military regimes in the Subcontinent were held out as examples of efficiency in the past. The broad approach was to keep India in play, and yet to also keep it in check. An unstable or weak India was as undesirable as a strong and domineering one. It was, in truth, a Goldilocks approach to the Indian porridge – not too hot, nor too cold, needing some effort to get it just right. And this was the India policy of most Western foreign offices. Therefore, we have the paradox of assisting India when it was really down after the 1962 conflict; yet of opposition when it asserts itself, as in the 1971 Bangladesh emergence. The phases in-between are of steady engagement but on a cautious scale. Indian aspirations of industrialization, building defence, nuclear or space capabilities or attaining positions of international influence were dealt with prudence, even while there was broad support for its development.

Much of this was rationalized by the argument that India, with its non-alignment policy, was not with the West in the Cold War. Understandably, the Indian narrative is very different and Western partiality for Pakistan is attributed as a reason for driving it closer to the Soviet bloc. All of this has, however, substantially changed. And with it, really, India's relationship with Western nations as a whole and its key players in particular.

There are, however, still divisive issues that speak for continuum of policy on both sides. On a range of economic and social questions, Indian and Western interests are quite divergent. Many involve policies where the welfare of millions is at stake. India also speaks for a larger developing